

Literature Review Workshop 2

This workshop develops your understanding of what a literature review *does*, beyond summarising existing research. The focus is on **critical analysis, relevance, and alignment with research objectives**, using real MPhil dissertations as exemplars.

Task 1 — Spot the difference: summary vs analysis

Exemplar (descriptive vs analytical use of literature)

Source: Lumbe, L. (2021). *The contribution of social housing as physical capital addressed in the “Smart City Wien Framework” to sustainable livelihoods.*

“The definitions of ‘smart city’ could not be more different (Ponting, 2013)... Hence, there is no universally accepted description of this notion. For the purposes of this dissertation, Toli and Murtagh’s (2020) characterisation will be applied...”
(Literature Review, pp. 7–8).

Why this is useful

This passage demonstrates careful coverage of definitions but only a **light analytical intervention**. It helps illustrate the boundary between high-quality description and explicit critical analysis.

Your task - Identify which sentences summarise existing work. - Identify where the author makes an analytical decision. - Rewrite one sentence to make the author’s judgement explicit.

Task 2 — Relevance filter (build judgement, not volume)

Exemplar (relevance-driven literature review)

Source: Bendavid, I. (2021). *How travellers' behaviour evolves with changes in shared e-scooter prices?*

“E-scooters may be an effective solution to urban congestion and the last-mile problem. However, action must be taken for this new transport mode to better complement, rather than compete with sustainable modes of transport... This section will draw the evolution of research on micro-mobility, e-scooters and the microeconomics and marketing tools used in this paper.” (Literature Review, p. 7).

Why this is useful

The author clearly filters the literature through the **research objective**, demonstrating that relevance is defined by the research question, not by topic popularity.

Your task - Identify which strands of literature are prioritised. - Identify at least one plausible strand that is implicitly excluded. - Explain how this filtering supports the research objective.

Task 3 — One-sentence synthesis drill

Exemplar (synthesis across authors)

Source: Macpherson-Smith, E. (2021). *Can urban regeneration unlock opportunities for women?*

“Early feminist urban planning literature... was primarily focused on the needs of white middle-class women in the suburbs... Contemporary research led by Beebejaun (2017) has instead attempted to reach historically marginalised women with a focus on intersectionality.” (Literature Review, pp. 7–8).

Why this is useful

This excerpt groups authors by **intellectual position and evolution**, rather than listing them individually. It is a clear example of synthesis.

Your task - Identify the organising principle used to group authors. - Write a one-sentence synthesis capturing the evolution of the debate. - Add a qualifier explaining why this evolution matters for the dissertation.

Task 4 — Name the gap type (avoid vague gap statements)

Exemplar (a defensible research gap)

Source: Macpherson-Smith, E. (2021). *Can urban regeneration unlock opportunities for women?*

“Despite this recent emergence there are still significant gaps in feminist urban planning literature, with notable omissions in the study of regeneration and the lived experiences of inner-city women.” (Literature Review, p. 7).

Why this is useful

The gap is defined as a **systematic omission**, not an absence of literature. This makes the gap credible and defensible.

Your task - Identify the type of gap (contextual, population, methodological). - Explain why this gap matters for the research objective. - Rewrite the gap in one sentence without using “there is little research”.

Task 5 — From literature to research design

Exemplar (literature review shaping method)

Source: Popham, E. (2021). *Legislating for Sustainable Development Using Spatial Justice Principles*.

“The aim of this literature review is to identify the spatial justice principles that are important to disrupt cycles of inequality... In order to establish an analytical framework... it is important to understand the key principles which represent spatial justice.” (Literature Review, pp. 8–9).

Why this is useful

This passage shows the literature review **actively constructing the research framework**, rather than serving as background.

Your task - Identify which concepts are carried forward into the framework. - Explain how theory is operationalised. - Suggest one alternative theory and how it would alter the research design.

Key takeaway

A strong literature review is not about demonstrating how much you have read. It is about demonstrating **judgement**: what matters, why it matters, and how it justifies the research you are about to undertake.